

THE AMOR-ROMA PROJECTS

Kindly note: These typographic projects were developed using the 2012 open-source typeface Crimson Roman by Sebastian Kosch, and were duly communicated to the author in August 2026 via X and GitHub, out of respect for his work and for his generosity in releasing the typeface under an open-source license. Full right to object, request adjustments, or withdraw association with these derivative projects is hereby granted to him, should he choose to exercise it.

Furthermore, these drafts are not intended as any form of typographic review — as will be clarified below — but rather as a response to the challenges that poor print quality and modern PDF rendering pose to typography and document production. They may contain artifacts and kerning issues that only professional type designers can fully resolve with appropriate software.

The projects are therefore made available on TypeDrawers, r/typography, and GitHub in order to gather any suggestions or reviews they may attract, all of which will be deeply appreciated. Thank you in advance for any feedback you may wish to share.

Contact: carlos.rueiro@gmail.com (pseudonymised email due to data harvesting and doxxing concerns), 10 August 2026.

2012 Crimson Roman by Sebastian Kosch

E F P K k y

Glyph refinements:

E F P K k y

Introduction

In recent years, many professionals and readers have begun to notice a curious and troubling phenomenon in everyday office printing—one that increasingly degrades the quality of modern document production. Traditional fonts that were once reliable now appear paler and distractingly thin, making on-screen reading unexpectedly tiring, if not outright uncomfortable. Meanwhile, low-quality or laser printing increasingly exposes and even distorts hinting and cursive imperfections that were once softened by ink bleed on paper.

At the same time, the inconsistent rendering behavior of different PDF readers has subjected carefully crafted typefaces to the agonies of poor formatting, reducing weeks or months of fine typographic tuning to the visual equivalent of fax-like output.

Times New Roman, once a dependable classic, now feels strangely lifeless and distracting both on screen and in print, demanding far more effort from the reader than its original design ever intended.

Furthermore, much like printing on inkjet, laser, and smart-tank devices—a practical necessity given that printer ink remains one of the most expensive liquids in the world—the very same PDF file can appear thin and overly smoothed in Adobe Reader, yet regain weight, clarity, and balance when opened in Microsoft Edge or Sumatra PDF.

Despite this, the discrepancy in display and print quality does not seem to be broadly acknowledged by professional type designers who—with notable exceptions such as Matthew Butterick (*Equity*) and Robert Slimbach (*Minion*)—appear to design primarily for high-quality displays and fine offset printing.

Open-source classics like *Crimson* and *Garamond* also suffer from this inconsistency, often rendered almost unrecognizably by standard office printers and default PDF viewers.

Therefore, aware of the impracticality of placing an offset press in every office and of the rising costs associated with high-quality inkjet printing, we pursued a different approach: updating a typeface specifically to anticipate and counter the quirks of Adobe Reader, inkjet printers, laser printers, and smart-tank systems—or at least to strike a more stable balance among them. Our goal was to identify a workhorse typeface that prioritizes consistency across these environments over formal typographic perfection.

Developed with patience, curiosity, and no claim to professional typographic mastery, this project builds on one of our favourite typefaces: Sebastian Kosch's 2012 open-source Crimson Roman. In our view, its innate elegance has long deserved a modern reinterpretation capable of reclaiming its place among the finest everyday serif typefaces under today's challenging display and print conditions.

We kindly suggest viewing this PDF first in Edge or Sumatra PDF, and only then in Adobe Reader, to experience firsthand how starkly different the rendering results can be.

This draft review presents a series of exploratory tests performed on Crimson Roman within the context of legal and academic writing, with the purpose of achieving greater consistency across the various display and print outcomes. Using FontForge and guided by AI analysis (Microsoft Copilot), these samples were evaluated both on screen and in print to understand how Crimson behaves under various typographic adjustments in today's digital-first, low-cost print environments.

These observations are practical, user-level findings focusing on paragraph color, x-height behavior, Roman/Italic balance, and OTF/TTF rendering robustness. Ultimately, this document illustrates the challenges of deploying Crimson in long-form legal text and showcases the adjustments that yielded the most promising results. All modifications presented here are working drafts rather than final design proposals.

All typographic experiments were carried out in FontForge, supported by analytical insights from AI (Microsoft Copilot). These tests were performed solely for research and documentation purposes, and do not constitute a redesign or replacement of the original Crimson Roman typeface.

Crimson Roman

Scale uniformly: ---

X-height: ---

Typo line gap: ---

Scale uniformly: ---

X & Y: ---

Style: ---

Format: Open Type

If the expression “Compliance Law” were to be described — as the evolution of its legal regime now appears to demand — as “all those regulations by virtue of which an undertaking would be required to adopt, assess, and enforce, within its business and trade, an overriding public interest as if it were one of its own governance purposes or profit-making interests”, surely the industry and the public, particularly in common-law jurisdictions, would always react with a considerable amount of surprise, if not outright challenge and defiance.

In fact, as they might ultimately observe, in its essence “compliance” would not amount to anything more than the mere “act of obeying a law or rule, especially one that controls a particular industry or type of work”, as the Cambridge Dictionary specifies and illustrates with the example: “this cake was made in strict compliance with its recipe”, and from which the industry would later frame its understanding of the term as the “specific requirements applicable to a service or product intended to be made available to the public or in a public market”.

OPTION 1. (Amor)

X-height: 445

Typo line gap: 270

Scale uniformly: 102%

X & Y: ---

Style: ---

Format: True Type

If the expression “Compliance Law” were to be described — as the evolution of its legal regime now appears to demand — as “all those regulations by virtue of which an undertaking would be required to adopt, assess, and enforce, within its business and trade, an overriding public interest as if it were one of its own governance purposes or profit-making interests”, surely the industry and the public, particularly in common-law jurisdictions, would always react with a considerable amount of surprise, if not outright challenge and defiance.

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TrueType format tends to deliver a more stable and consistent result under poor rasterization, weak anti-aliasing, or low-quality laser printing. Even these modest adjustments significantly improve Crimson’s performance across common office-grade output systems. It is our preferred variant in terms of elegance and fidelity to Crimson’s original spirit.

OPTION 2. (Amor B)

X-height: 450

Typo line gap: 270

Scale uniformly: 102%

X & Y: ---

Style: ---

Format: True Type

If the expression “Compliance Law” were to be described — as the evolution of its legal regime now appears to demand — as “all those regulations by virtue of which an undertaking would be required to adopt, assess, and enforce, within its business and trade, an overriding public interest as if it were one of its own governance purposes or profit-making interests”, surely the industry and the public, particularly in common-law jurisdictions, would always react with a considerable amount of surprise, if not outright challenge and defiance.

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The increased x-height improves readability at smaller sizes, but the 5-pt rise introduces noticeable imbalance in display environments. While technically stronger in low-quality printing, this variant departs more visibly from Crimson’s classical proportions, making it a functional but less stylistically faithful interpretation.

OPTION 3. (Roma)

X-height: 445

Typo line gap: 270

Scale uniformly: 102%

X & Y: ---

Style: 1

Format: True Type

If the expression “Compliance Law” were to be described — as the evolution of its legal regime now appears to demand — as “all those regulations by virtue of which an undertaking would be required to adopt, assess, and enforce, within its business and trade, an overriding public interest as if it were one of its own governance purposes or profit-making interests”, surely the industry and the public, particularly in common-law jurisdictions, would always react with a considerable amount of surprise, if not outright challenge and defiance.

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Roma offers the most stable and predictable behaviour across all environments. Style 1 combined with a moderate x-height increase preserves Crimson’s original elegance while improving robustness under weak anti-aliasing and poor rasterization. This balance makes Roma the safest all-purpose configuration for mixed digital-and-print workflows.

OPTION 4. (Roma B)

X-height: 450

Typo line gap: 270

Scale uniformly: 102%

X & Y: ---

Style: 1

Format: True Type

If the expression “Compliance Law” were to be described — as the evolution of its legal regime now appears to demand — as “all those regulations by virtue of which an undertaking would be required to adopt, assess, and enforce, within its business and trade, an overriding public interest as if it were one of its own governance purposes or profit-making interests”, surely the industry and the public, particularly in common-law jurisdictions, would always react with a considerable amount of surprise, if not outright challenge and defiance.

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The higher x-height enhances readability and strengthens paragraph colour, particularly in legal and academic text. However, this comes at the cost of reducing Crimson’s inherent delicacy and classical refinement. Roma B is a practical, high-legibility variant best suited for dense text and office-grade printing.

OPTION 5. (Romanista)

X-height: 445

Typo line gap: 270

Scale uniformly: 102%

X & Y: ---

Style: 2

Format: True Type

If the expression “Compliance Law” were to be described — as the evolution of its legal regime now appears to demand — as “all those regulations by virtue of which an undertaking would be required to adopt, assess, and enforce, within its business and trade, an overriding public interest as if it were one of its own governance purposes or profit-making interests”, surely the industry and the public, particularly in common-law jurisdictions, would always react with a considerable amount of surprise, if not outright challenge and defiance.

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Romanista retains Crimson’s original proportions while adopting Style 2’s more assertive structure. This variant offers a subtle increase in clarity without compromising elegance, making it a refined alternative for readers who prefer a slightly darker text colour without altering x-height.

OPTION 6. (Romanesca)

X-height: 450

Typo line gap: 270

Scale uniformly: 102%

X & Y: ---

Style: 2

Format: True Type

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Romanesca’s increased x-height and Style 2 construction produce a noticeably stronger text block, improving legibility in low-quality printing and PDF rendering. Although less faithful to Crimson’s original delicacy, it performs reliably in environments where clarity and resilience outweigh strict stylistic preservation.

OPTION 7. (Romanesca B)

X-height: 450

Typo line gap: 270

Scale uniformly: 102%

X & Y: 78 - 112

Style: 2

Format: True Type

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Romanesca B combines Style 2 with expanded X/Y scaling, resulting in the densest and most assertive paragraph colour of all variants. This configuration maximizes robustness under poor rasterization and office-grade printing, though it represents the furthest departure from Crimson’s classical balance. It is the most utilitarian option for challenging production environments.

AMOR, comparison with Times New Roman:

If the expression “Compliance Law” were to be described — as the evolution of its legal regime now appears to demand — as “all those regulations by virtue of which an undertaking would be required to adopt, assess, and enforce, within its business and trade, an overriding public interest as if it were one of its own governance or profit-making purposes”, surely the industry and the public — particularly in common-law jurisdictions — would always react with considerable surprise, if not outright challenge and defiance. (size 12 pts, leading 1 pt)

If the expression “Compliance Law” were to be described — as the evolution of its legal regime now appears to demand — as “all those regulations by virtue of which an undertaking would be required to adopt, assess, and enforce, within its business and trade, an overriding public interest as if it were one of its own governance or profit-making purposes”, surely the industry and the public — particularly in common-law jurisdictions — would always react with considerable surprise, if not outright challenge and defiance. (size 12 pts, leading: 1,15).

Amor B, comparison with Times New Roman:

If the expression “Compliance Law” were to be described — as the evolution of its legal regime now appears to demand — as “all those regulations by virtue of which an undertaking would be required to adopt, assess, and enforce, within its business and trade, an overriding public interest as if it were one of its own governance or profit-making purposes”, surely the industry and the public — particularly in common-law jurisdictions — would always react with considerable surprise, if not outright challenge and defiance. (size 12 pts, leading 1 pt)

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ROMA, comparison with Times New Roman:

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ROMA B, Comparison with Times New Roman:

If the expression “Compliance Law” were to be described — as the evolution of its legal regime now appears to demand — as “all those regulations by virtue of which an undertaking would be required to adopt, assess, and enforce, within its business and trade, an overriding public interest as if it were one of its own governance or profit-making purposes”, surely the industry and the public — particularly in common-law jurisdictions — would always react with considerable surprise, if not outright challenge and defiance. (size 12 pts, leading 1 pt)

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ROMANISTA, comparison with Times New Roman:

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ROMANESCA, comparison with Times New Roman:

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AI Conclusions (MS Copilot)

The exploratory adjustments presented in this document illustrate how Crimson Roman responds to a variety of typographic conditions relevant to legal and academic writing, particularly in environments affected by inconsistent PDF rendering, weak anti-aliasing, and low-quality office printing. While the original design retains exceptional elegance and classical balance, its low x-height, delicate outlines, and narrow lowercase proportions expose the typeface to several challenges in modern digital workflows and everyday print systems.

Across the tested configurations, the variants demonstrated distinct behaviours rather than a single hierarchy of quality. Amor preserves the closest connection to Crimson’s original spirit, offering improved stability through TrueType export while maintaining elegance. Amor B, with its increased x-height, enhances readability but introduces display imbalance, making it a functional yet less stylistically faithful interpretation.

Roma, using Style 1 and a moderate x-height increase to 445, proved to be the most stable and predictable option across all environments. It strengthens paragraph colour and improves robustness under poor rasterization while remaining visually aligned with Crimson’s design philosophy. Roma B, by contrast, adopts Style 1 and an x-height of 450, producing a darker, more legible text block suited for dense legal and academic writing, though at the cost of reducing Crimson’s inherent delicacy.

The Style 2 variants—Romanista, Romanesca, and Romanesca B—offer progressively stronger paragraph colour and improved resilience in office-grade printing. Romanista retains much of Crimson’s elegance while subtly increasing clarity; Romanesca enhances legibility through a higher x-height; and Romanesca B provides the densest and most assertive text block, maximizing robustness in challenging production environments.

These observations should not be interpreted as definitive typographic solutions, but rather as practical findings from real-world experimentation conducted in FontForge with analytical support from AI (Microsoft Copilot). They suggest that Crimson Roman has significant potential for professional legal and academic contexts if revisited with contemporary production realities in mind.

Ultimately, the variants presented here represent complementary interpretations of Crimson, each adapted to different workflows, rendering conditions, and printing constraints. They demonstrate that even modest adjustments—to x-height, style, scaling, line gap, and export format—can meaningfully improve performance while preserving, to varying degrees, the character of Sebastian Kosch’s original design.

“Amor”

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Consequently — as it would further be concluded — just as civil and commercial law were to stand as the law of individuals, prescribing and proscribing their actions and behaviour, “compliance law”, in turn, would stand as the “law of products and services”, thereby requiring, to name only a few examples, lawyers to offer their services in accordance with applicable professional ethics (conflict of interest, independence, probity, good faith, etc.); manufacturers to place toys, electrical devices, cosmetics, or medicines on the market only after ensuring they pose no hazards to the public (product compliance); and financial institutions to grant loans or undertake investments without breaching minimum capital and solvency requirements.

Notwithstanding, while such statements must indeed be acknowledged as true — and compliance, therefore, understood, by default, as the legal regime governing the public marketing of certain products and services (the “law of all regulated markets”) — it must equally be outlined that, at the same time, such a narrow description would (...)

“Amor B”

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“Roma”

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“Roma B”

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“Romanista”

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“Romanesca” (size 11,5)

If the expression “Compliance Law” were to be described — as the evolution of its legal regime now appears to demand — as “all those regulations by virtue of which an undertaking would be required to adopt, assess, and enforce, within its business and trade, an overriding public interest as if it were one of its own governance purposes or profit-making interests”, surely the industry and the public, particularly in common-law jurisdictions, would always react with a considerable amount of surprise, if not outright challenge and defiance.

In fact, as they might ultimately observe, in its essence “compliance” would not amount to anything more than the mere “act of obeying a law or rule, especially one that controls a particular industry or type of work”, as the Cambridge Dictionary specifies and illustrates with the example: “this cake was made in strict compliance with its recipe”, and from which the industry would later frame its understanding of the term as the “specific requirements applicable to a service or product intended to be made available to the public or in a public market”.

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“Romanesca B”

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